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PLAYLIST

THE WORLD CUP AND THE WORLD BEYOND

The game's **biggest spectacle returns** shaped as much by geopolitics and commerce as by football itself.

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The FIFA World Cup is a story about time. Every four years, it arrives carrying the weight of memory and the promise of change. It is a stage where generations overlap, where legends seek one final chapter while young stars attempt to write their first. For more than a decade and a half, football has revolved around a familiar constellation of stars. Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo defined an era through relentless excellence. Neymar carried the expectations of Brazil, while Luka Modric became the symbol of a smaller nation's ability to challenge the established powers.

Now, a new order seeks to overthrow them. Erling Haaland arrives carrying Norway's hopes, while Lamine Yamal and Pedri embody a rejuvenated Spain. Ousmane Dembele, fresh from a Ballon d'Or win, joins Kylian Mbappe at the forefront of France's ambitions to regain the trophy. Across the tournament, the old guard and the new will share the same stage, each chasing a different place in history.

Yet they will do so at a World Cup shaped by forces far beyond football.

The World Cup has always mirrored the world around it. In 1934, it marched through the shadows of fascism. In 1978, it unfolded under Argentina's military dictatorship. Qatar 2022, the first World Cup in the Arab world, was held against a backdrop of migrant labour controversies and a winter schedule that forced football to abandon its traditional calendar. Now, in 2026, football arrives in North America, traversing three nations, 16 cities and 104 matches involving 48 teams.

This is a World Cup spread across borders at a time when the world increasingly feels fenced off.

With Donald Trump back in the